

Anti-Inflammatory Herbs and Spices for Arthritis: A Complete

Evidence-based guide to anti-inflammatory herbs and spices for arthritis. Learn about ginger, cinnamon, garlic, rosemary and other natural remedies available in the UK.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Advisory Panel** (HCPC-registered physiotherapy & rheumatology nursing input) · 2026-01-16 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk



*Collection of anti-inflammatory spices and herbs including turmeric, ginger, garlic and cinnamon on a wooden board
Openly licensed image via Openverse*

For centuries, herbs and spices have been used to treat pain and inflammation. Modern science is now validating many of these traditional remedies, identifying the

specific compounds responsible for their anti-inflammatory effects and testing them in clinical trials. While no herb or spice can replace medical treatment for arthritis, several have genuine evidence supporting their use as complementary approaches. This guide examines the most promising options available in UK shops and supermarkets.

Ginger (*Zingiber officinale*)

The Evidence

Ginger is one of the most extensively studied anti-inflammatory spices for arthritis. Its active compounds — gingerols, shogaols and paradols — inhibit the same inflammatory pathways (COX-2, LOX, NF-κB) targeted by conventional anti-inflammatory medications. A meta-analysis of five randomised controlled trials found that ginger significantly reduced pain and disability in osteoarthritis, with effects comparable to ibuprofen in some studies. The evidence is strongest for knee osteoarthritis.

How to Use

- Fresh ginger — Grate 1–2 cm into stir-fries, soups, smoothies or hot water for ginger tea
- Ground ginger — ½–1 teaspoon daily added to cooking, porridge or warm drinks
- Supplements — 500–1,000 mg daily of ginger extract (available from Holland & Barrett, Boots)
- Ginger tea — Steep fresh sliced ginger in boiling water for 10 minutes. Add honey and lemon

Safety

Generally very safe. May cause mild heartburn in some people. Can interact with blood-thinning medications (warfarin) — check with your GP. Not recommended in doses exceeding 4g daily.

Cinnamon (*Cinnamomum*)



Openly licensed image via Openverse

The Evidence

Cinnamon contains cinnamaldehyde and proanthocyanidins, which have demonstrated anti-inflammatory effects in laboratory studies. A systematic review found cinnamon supplementation reduced inflammatory markers (CRP) in people with metabolic conditions. Limited but promising research specifically in arthritis suggests potential benefits for reducing joint inflammation and oxidative stress.

How to Use

- Sprinkle on porridge, yoghurt, smoothies or baked fruit
- Add to warm milk or coffee (golden milk with turmeric and cinnamon is popular)
- Use Ceylon cinnamon ("true cinnamon") rather than cassia cinnamon, as cassia contains higher levels of coumarin which can affect the liver in large amounts
- 1–3g daily is commonly used

Garlic (*Allium sativum*)

The Evidence

Garlic contains diallyl disulphide (DADS), a compound that limits cartilage-damaging enzymes in laboratory studies. A large epidemiological study published in *BMC Musculoskeletal Disorders* found that women who consumed more garlic had significantly lower rates of hip osteoarthritis. While clinical trial evidence specifically for arthritis pain is limited, garlic's anti-inflammatory properties are well documented.

How to Use

- Use 1–2 fresh cloves daily in cooking — crush or chop and let stand for 10 minutes before cooking to maximise allicin production
- Raw garlic is most potent but harder to tolerate — roasted garlic is milder and still beneficial
- Aged garlic extract supplements are available for those who dislike the taste

Rosemary (*Rosmarinus officinalis*)



Openly licensed image via Openverse

The Evidence

Rosemary contains rosmarinic acid and carnosic acid, both potent antioxidants with anti-inflammatory properties. Laboratory studies show these compounds inhibit COX-2 and reduce inflammatory cytokines. While clinical trial evidence in arthritis is still emerging, the anti-inflammatory mechanisms are well characterised.

How to Use

- Add fresh or dried rosemary liberally to roasted vegetables, meats and soups
- Make rosemary tea by steeping a sprig in hot water for 5–10 minutes
- Rosemary oil can be used topically (diluted in a carrier oil) for joint massage

Green Tea (*Camellia sinensis*)

The Evidence

Green tea contains epigallocatechin-3-gallate (EGCG), a powerful anti-inflammatory polyphenol. Research published in *Arthritis Research & Therapy* found EGCG reduced inflammation and cartilage destruction in laboratory models of arthritis. Epidemiological studies suggest regular green tea consumption is associated with lower rates of arthritis and reduced inflammatory markers.

How to Use

- Drink 2–3 cups of green tea daily — brew at 70–80°C (not boiling) for 2–3 minutes
 - Matcha provides concentrated EGCG
 - Green tea supplements are available but may interact with some medications
-

Black Pepper (*Piper nigrum*)

The Evidence

Piperine, the active compound in black pepper, has anti-inflammatory properties and — crucially — dramatically improves the absorption of curcumin from turmeric (by up to 2,000%). It also enhances the bioavailability of other beneficial compounds. Always combine turmeric with black pepper for maximum benefit.

Combining Herbs and Spices

A practical approach to incorporating anti-inflammatory herbs and spices into your daily routine:

- Morning — Golden milk (warm milk with ½ tsp turmeric, pinch of black pepper, ½ tsp cinnamon, ½ tsp ginger)
- Lunch — Add fresh garlic and rosemary to soups or salads
- Afternoon — Green tea
- Dinner — Cook with ginger, garlic and plenty of herbs and spices

While individual spices may have modest effects, the cumulative benefit of an overall anti-inflammatory dietary pattern — rich in herbs, spices, fruits, vegetables and whole grains — is well supported by evidence. Our virtual assistant can help you plan anti-inflammatory

meals using these ingredients.

This article is for general information only. Herbs and spices complement but do not replace medical treatment. Consult your GP before taking herbal supplements, particularly if you take prescription medications.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about anti-inflammatory herbs and spices for arthritis: a complete?

Short answer: Several herbs and spices available in UK shops have genuine anti-inflammatory evidence for arthritis, including turmeric (curcumin), ginger, garlic, cinnamon, rosemary and boswellia. None replace medical treatment, but the strongest data are for curcumin at around 1,000 mg/day with an absorption aid, and ginger extract at 500–1,000 mg/day. Use consistently for 4–12 weeks before judging effect.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Versus Arthritis: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis UK · livingwitharthritis.org.uk